

MONGOL INVASION

The Mongols invaded China in 1271, and established the Yuan dynasty (1271-1368). As the Mongols were not interested in the refined style of Chinese tea culture, preferring their own rustic form of preparation, indigenous Chinese tea culture started to disappear. Once the Ming Dynasty (1368-1644) came to power after the Mongols, tea processing styles evolved from pressed brick form to loose leaf.



MONGOLIAN TEA

The salty yak butter tea was, and still is, an essential element of the Mongolian diet.

1271

The Mongols invade China and Song dynasty tea traditions are lost

1610

The Portuguese start to import tea from China

1658

An advertisement in a London newspaper announces the availability of tea, known at the time as the "China drink," in a London coffeehouse. Only small amounts of tea are available in Britain at this time

1590s

Portuguese missionary priests send letters home from China describing tea

1619

The Dutch set up port in Batavia (now Jakarta), Indonesia to import tea and export it throughout Europe

1664

The East India Company begins to import tea from China into Britain via Java

TEA CRAZE

In the 16th century, the Portuguese were the first Europeans to drink tea, but it was the Dutch who made it popular. The Dutch became the largest importers of tea, and traded with other European countries. Due to its high price it was a drink exclusively for the wealthy.



EAST INDIA COMPANY

Formed in 1600 as a private company, the British East India Company (EIC) grew to be an all-powerful monopoly controlling half the world's trade. Although they began importing all of Britain's tea from China, they would go on to cultivate their own tea-growing source to supply Britain and its colonies.